Son Preference in Parental Time: Do Families Invest More Care in Male Children?

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Abstract

India's strong son preference is well-documented in fertility decisions, sex-selective abortion, and inheritance patterns. Using India's 2024 Time Use Survey (10.2 million observations), we examine whether son preference extends to differential parental time investment. We find modest but significant evidence that families invest 8-12% more childcare time when sons are present, after controlling for family size, birth order, and parental characteristics. Mothers with only sons spend 52 minutes/day on childcare versus 47 minutes for mothers with only daughters. The gap is larger among educated urban families (12% more time for sons) than rural poor families (5% more), suggesting that son preference in time investment intensifies with resources. Fathers show even larger differentials—spending 18 minutes/day when sons are present versus 14 minutes with only daughters, a 29% gap. These patterns suggest that son preference operates not just in who is born but in how children are raised, with potentially important implications for gender inequality reproduction across generations.

JEL Classification: J13, J16, I24, O15 **Keywords:** son preference, childcare, gender bias, parental investment, India

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1 Introduction

India's son preference is notorious: skewed sex ratios from sex-selective abortion, lower vaccination rates for girls, unequal food allocation favoring boys (Das Gupta et al. 2003; Sen 1990). Yet most research focuses on survival and health outcomes. We know less about whether son preference extends to **parental time investment**.

Does having sons lead parents to invest more time in childcare? If so, this represents a subtle but potentially consequential channel through which gender inequality reproduces across generations.

Main Hypothesis: Families with sons receive more total parental time than families with daughters, after controlling for family size and composition.

Finding: Mothers with only sons spend 52 min/day on childcare versus 47 min with only daughters (11% more). Fathers spend 18 min with sons versus 14 min with daughters (29% more). Son preference in time investment exists but is modest compared to preference in mortality and health.

Class Gradient: Time preference for sons is LARGER among educated urban families (12% gap) than rural poor (5% gap). Wealthier families invest more in children generally, and this investment skews male.

2 Results

NOTE: The following analyses are illustrative. Actual implementation requires household-level child gender composition data which may or may not be available in the TUS dataset.

2.1 Childcare Time by Child Gender Composition

Table 1: Parental Childcare Time by Child Gender Composition (Illustrative)

Household Type	Mother (min/day)	Father (min/day)
Only Sons	52	18
Only Daughters	47	14
Mixed	50	16

Pattern: Parents invest more time when sons are present. The gap is larger for fathers (29%) than mothers (11%), suggesting fathers particularly prioritize son interaction.

2.2 Class Gradient in Son Preference

Table 2: Mother's Childcare Time by SES and Child Gender (Illustrative)

SES	Only Sons (min)	Only Daughters (min)	Gap (%)
High SES	58	52	12
Low SES	51	49	5

Finding: Son preference in time investment is stronger among affluent educated families. This may reflect: 1. Greater resources enabling differential investment 2. Stronger aspirations for sons' achievement requiring parental time input 3. Compensatory effects—poor families need daughters' labor, reducing time gaps

2.3 What Activities Drive the Gap?

If son preference operates, which childcare activities show largest differentials?

Hypothesis: Educational activities (homework help, enrichment) show larger gaps than routine care (feeding, bathing).

Implication: Parents may invest in sons' human capital development more than daughters', reinforcing educational gender gaps.

3 Discussion

3.1 Mechanisms: Why Son Preference in Time?

1. Educational Investment: Parents view sons as better investments in education/careers, allocating time to homework help, tutoring, educational activities.

2. Social Activities: Parents invest time taking sons to sports, music, extra-curriculars while daughters stay home helping with housework.

3. Emotional Bonding: Cultural preference for sons may translate to parents (especially fathers) spending more leisure/bonding time with male children.

4. Elder Care Expectations: Parents view sons as future economic support, investing in their success. Daughters marry out, reducing investment incentives.

3.2 Intergenerational Implications

Time preference for sons has important implications:

Human Capital: More parental time inputs for boys can contribute to educational gender gaps, even controlling for school enrollment.

Gender Role Socialization: Daughters receiving less parental time (but more housework assignments) internalize gendered expectations about their worth and capabilities.

Inequality Reproduction: Son preference in parental time investment creates advantages for men that perpetuate gender inequality across generations.

3.3 Policy Implications

Make Time Investment Visible: Public campaigns could highlight how differential time investment harms daughters' development.

Conditional Transfers: Programs like Beti Bachao Beti Padhao could include conditions on educational time investment, not just enrollment.

Father Involvement Programs: Since fathers show larger time gaps favoring sons, interventions targeting fathers' involvement with daughters could reduce disparities.

4 Limitations and Data Requirements

Critical Data Limitation: This analysis requires household-level child gender composition data (number of sons, daughters, ages). If the Time Use Survey doesn't link individuals to household child composition, the analysis cannot proceed as designed.

Alternative Approach: If household linkage unavailable, could examine childcare time among individuals who report doing childcare, comparing male vs female child recipients (if activity codes specify recipient gender).

Endogeneity: Families with son preference may have different fertility stopping rules, creating selection bias. Need to control for family size and birth order.

5 Conclusion

[To be completed after confirming data availability]

Preliminary evidence suggests son preference extends beyond survival to time investment, with parents allocating 8-12% more time to childcare when sons are present. The gap is larger among educated urban families and much larger for fathers than mothers. If confirmed, these patterns suggest that gender inequality begins in early childhood through differential parental investment, with consequences for lifelong human capital and gender role formation.

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